Chapter 4

Introducing ChatGPT

IN THIS CHAPTER

- **Comparing ChatGPT versions**
- **Establishing a ChatGPT account**
- **Learning ChatGPT's user interface**
- **Choosing between features and options**
- **Making and managing ChatGPT outputs**

The *Chat* in ChatGPT's name is a reference to its use of natural-language processing and natural-language generation. *GPT* stands for generative pretrained transformer, which is a deep learning neural network model developed by OpenAI, an American AI research and development company. You can think of GPT as the secret sauce that makes ChatGPT work as it does. In short, ChatGPT is a GPT-based chatbot.

ChatGPT is a huge phenomenon and a major paradigm shift in the accelerating march of technological progression. It's a chatbot that can run on one of several large language models (LLMs) developed and offered by a company called OpenAI. Like other GenAI chatbots, ChatGPT doesn't create original content in the purely creative sense; rather, it remixes data to produce new content that's calculated and contrived in response to a user's question or command — both of which are referred to as a prompt.

Users can (and often do) access ChatGPT directly online at `https://chat.openai.com/`, but it's also integrated with several existing applications. Typically, you can access ChatGPT embedded in other applications simply by signing onto that application in the usual way. The number of app integrations seems to grow every day as existing software providers hurry to capitalize on ChatGPT's popularity. ChatGPT can also be accessed via apps on mobile devices.

Comparing Different Account Versions of ChatGPT

ChatGPT offers several account versions to suit different user needs: Free Plus, Teams, Pro, and Enterprise. The free version of ChatGPT has received significant upgrades, but you may prefer the Plus version for its higher usage limits and additional features. Free users may also encounter slower response times during peak hours and more limited availability.

Here's a brief look at the paid versions of ChatGPT:

- **ChatGPT Plus,** with a monthly subscription fee of $20, offers faster responses and priority access, which gives you more powerful and consistent performance. For businesses or collaborative settings, the ChatGPT Teams subscription plan offers more flexibility through multiuser access, administrative controls, and shared workspaces. The Teams version caters to groups working together on projects or customer support.
- **ChatGPT Pro** comes at a much higher price. For $200 a month, you get "the best of OpenAI with the highest level of access," the company says. Currently, that means everything available in the ChatGPT Plus version and unlimited access to GPT-4o and o1 plus unlimited access to advanced voice and access to o1 pro mode. I haven't yet found sufficient need for the Pro features to justify the higher monthly subscription cost. But your mileage may vary.
- **ChatGPT Enterprise,** for larger organizations, delivers advanced features such as unlimited access, longer inputs (prompts), integration options, enhanced security, higher customization, and comprehensive analytics. This version is designed for businesses with large-scale needs, including better privacy controls and support for more complex operations and larger or more numerous team collaborations. Pricing is customized for the organization's size and needs.

Setting Up an Individual Account

To set up an individual account and enter your first prompt, take the following steps:

1. **Go to** `https://openai.com/blog/chatgpt`.
   Returning users can go straight to `https://chat.openai.com/` and skip the rest of the steps.
2. **Click the Try ChatGPT button. You don't have to create an account to try ChatGPT this way.**

   REMEMBER However, this version is limited and not truly representative of the premium versions that have an escalating number of features to match the bigger price tags.
3. **Or, follow the prompts to create your OpenAI account.**
   After you have registered for an OpenAI account, select the subscription plan you prefer. The cost for a ChatGPT Plus subscription, as of this writing, is $20 per month. Other subscription plans are also available: Teams at $25 per month, Pro at $200 per month, and Enterprise, which requires a call with an OpenAI salesperson to get a quote on the price for your company needs. Having an OpenAI account also gives you access to other AI apps built on OpenAI models, such as DALL-E.
4. **When ChatGPT opens, enter your prompt in the prompt bar, as shown in Figure 4-1.**
   ChatGPT will then generate a response.
5. **If you want to continue the dialogue, enter another prompt.**
6. **When you're finished, rate the response by clicking the thumbs up or thumbs down icon.**
   Doing so helps fine-tune the AI model.
7. **When you're finished using ChatGPT, log out or simply close the window in your browser.**



WARNING In some subscription plans, OpenAI's team can see any information you enter in the prompt and the entire conversation that ensues. They may use this data in training other AI models. See a key disclosure in OpenAI's privacy policy in Figure 4-2 and check out the full policy at `https://openai.com/policies/row-privacy-policy/`. When using ChatGPT, don't disclose anything you want to keep private or confidential.

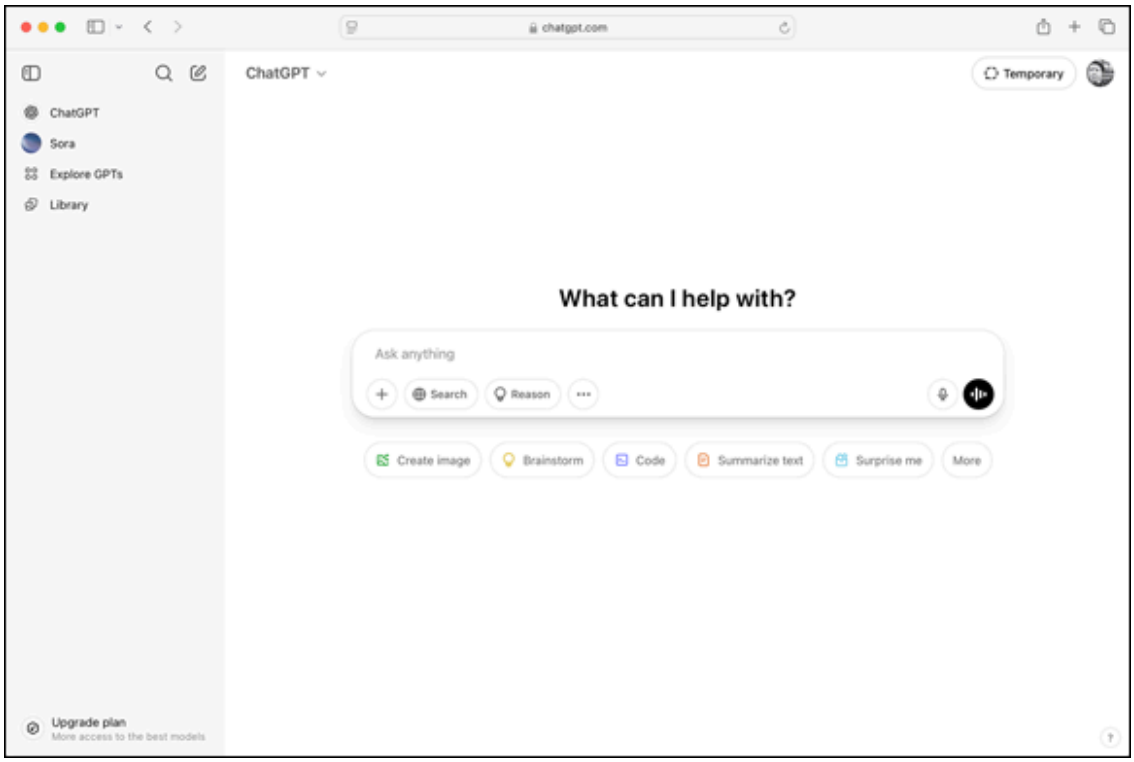


FIGURE 4-1: ChatGPT Plus UI.

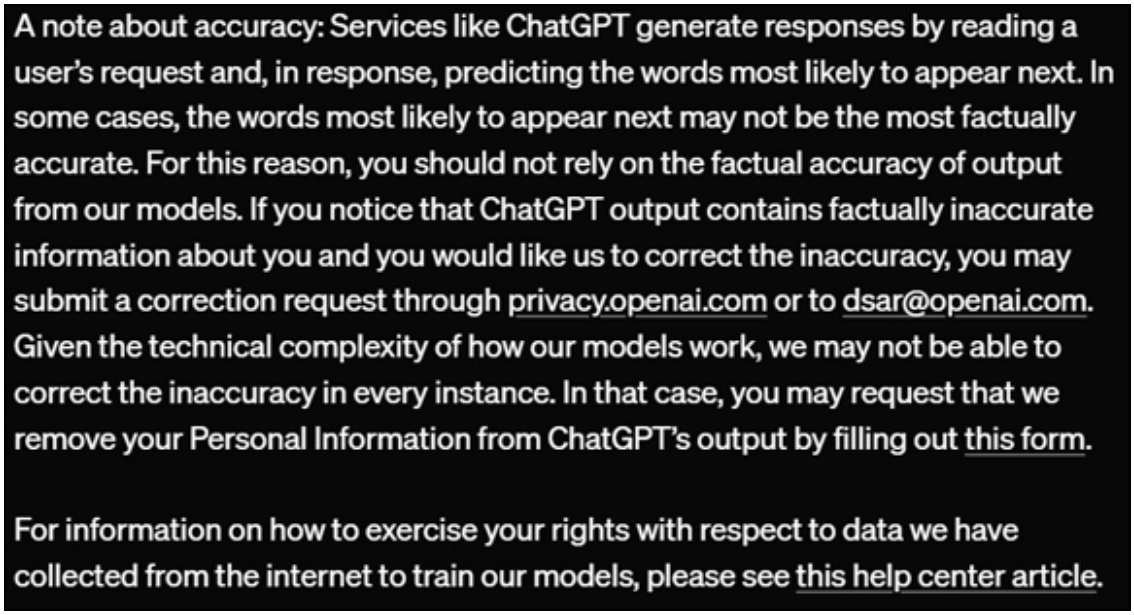


FIGURE 4-2: A key disclosure in OpenAI's privacy policy found in full at `https://openai.com/policies/row-privacy-policy/`.

Touring the User Interface

The following will guide you through the essential parts of the ChatGPT Plus user interface (UI) so you'll know where to find the information and features you need. Anywhere you encounter ChatGPT, such as embedded in other software or in other versions of ChatGPT, the UI will be similar.

You may want to refer to Figure 4-1 again because it's a screenshot of the full UI. What follows is a list of the parts of the UI with an explanation of each.

1. Far left of the UI at the top of the sidebar: This part of the UI contains a Close Sidebar button on the left, a chat search icon in the middle, and a New Chat button on the right, which starts a new chat rather than you simply continuing in the current chat session (see Figure 4-3).



FIGURE 4-3: Close Sidebar button on the left, chat search icon in the middle, and Start New Chat button on the right. All three are at the top left of the UI.

2. Directly below those buttons on the same sidebar are another New Chat start button and the Explore GPTs button (see Figure 4-4). The former is just an alternate way to start a new chat, whereas the latter takes you to the GPT Store, where you'll find a collection of GPT minis, which are smaller applications tailored to perform specific tasks. Whichever GPT minis you choose will also be listed here afterward, making it easier for you to return to those again later.

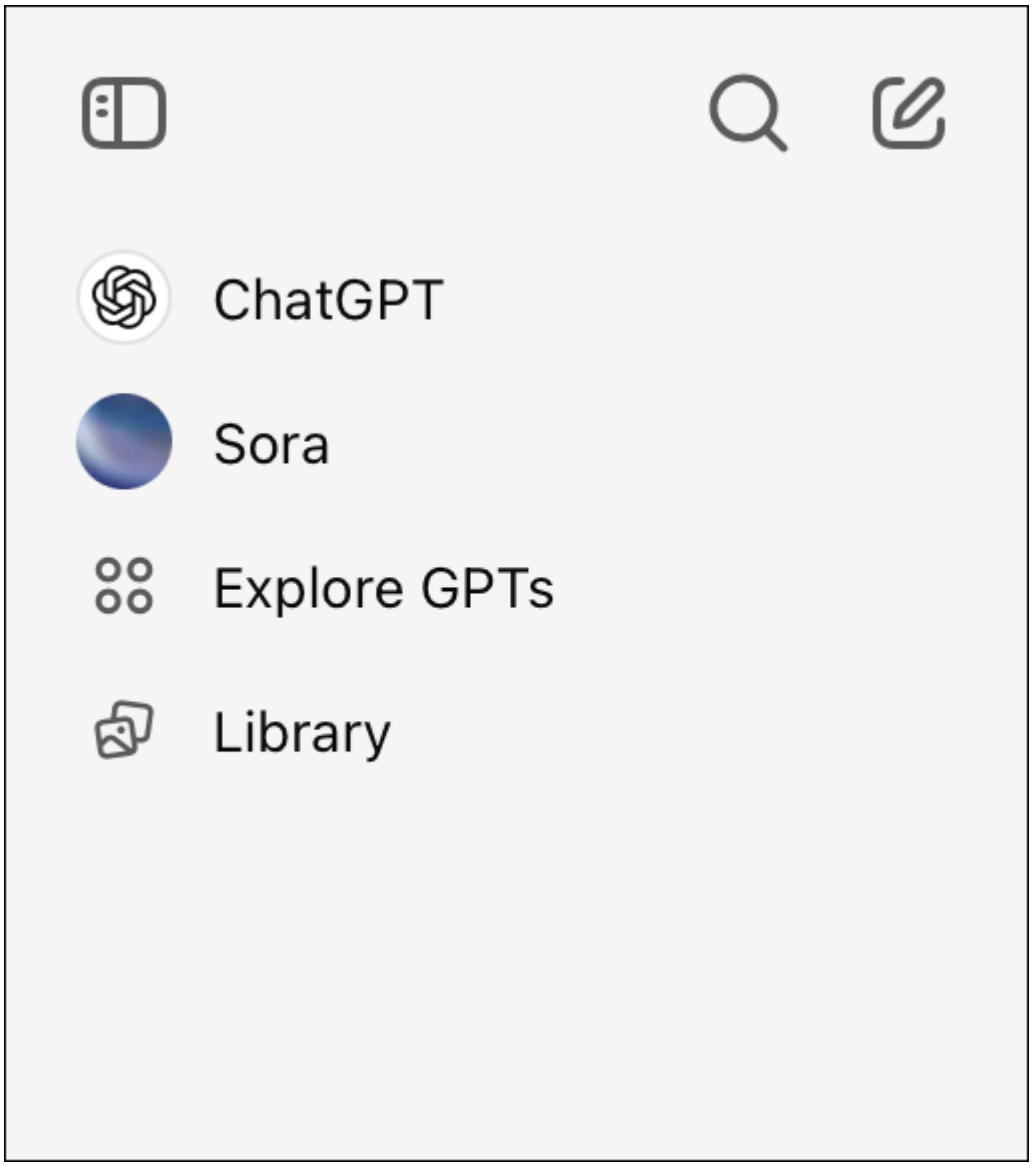


FIGURE 4-4: Upper part of sidebar found on left side of UI showing the New Chat start button, a list of GPT minis previously selected, and an Explore GPTs button, which takes you to the GPT Store.

3. When you click on the Explore GPTs button, it will take you to the page shown in Figure 4-5. You can either use the search bar or simply scroll through the selection to find a GPT mini that's already customized to perform whatever task you need.

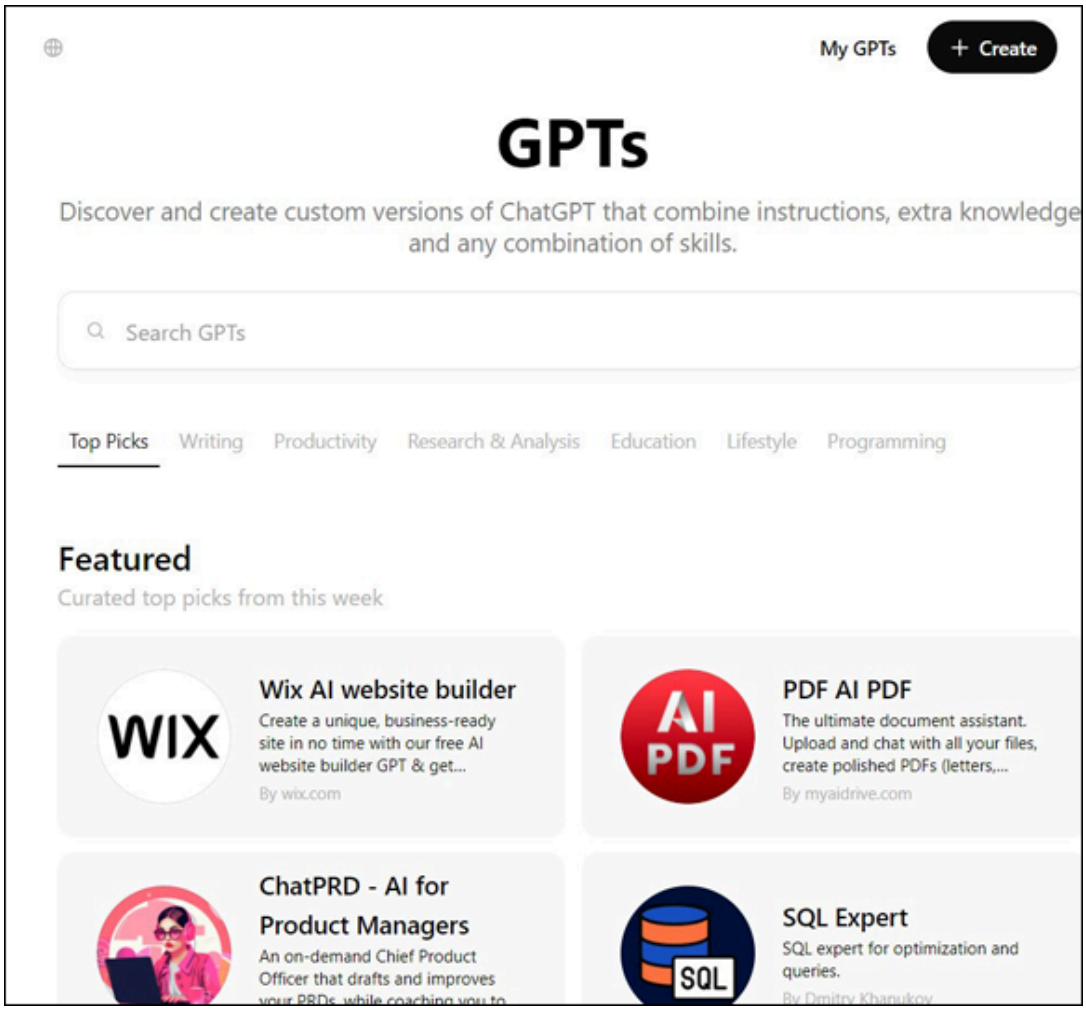


FIGURE 4-5: A screenshot of the GPT Store page.

4. The rest of the sidebar lists your chat histories. You can revisit and resume any chat that's listed there. You can also archive, rename, or delete any chat by clicking on the three dots at the upper right of each chat and selecting an action from the drop-down options.
5. At the bottom of the sidebar is a button that enables you to upgrade your subscription at any time.
6. Moving right is the main body of the UI, which is everything on the UI that's to the right of the sidebar. At the top is a drop-down menu of OpenAI's generative AI models (Figure 4-6). Choose one for your chat to run on.
7. At the center of the UI main body is the OpenAI logo, which doesn't do anything, but it looks pretty (see Figure 4-7).
8. Beneath the logo are suggested prompts you can use as a demo of this application, or just because you're curious about that topic. Click on one if you want to see ChatGPT do its thing.
9. At the bottom of the UI main body is the prompt bar. This is where you'll type your query or command for ChatGPT to respond to. To continue the chat, simply prompt again after ChatGPT responds to your earlier prompt. To change the conversation, click on one of the two New Chat start buttons on the UI and detailed earlier in the UI tour list.

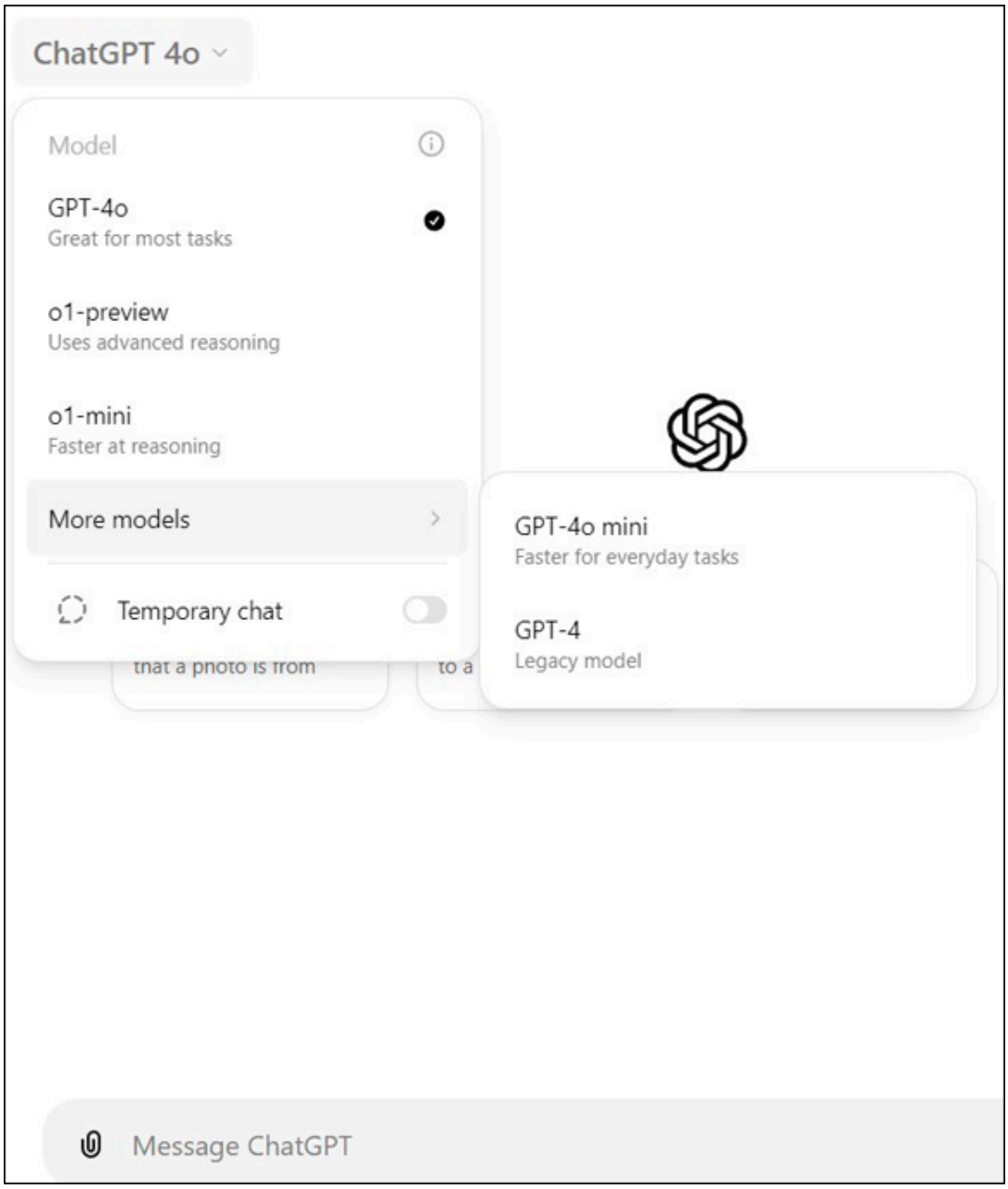


FIGURE 4-6: The list of AI model options offered in the drop-down menu at the top left center, which is to say on the main body of the UI.

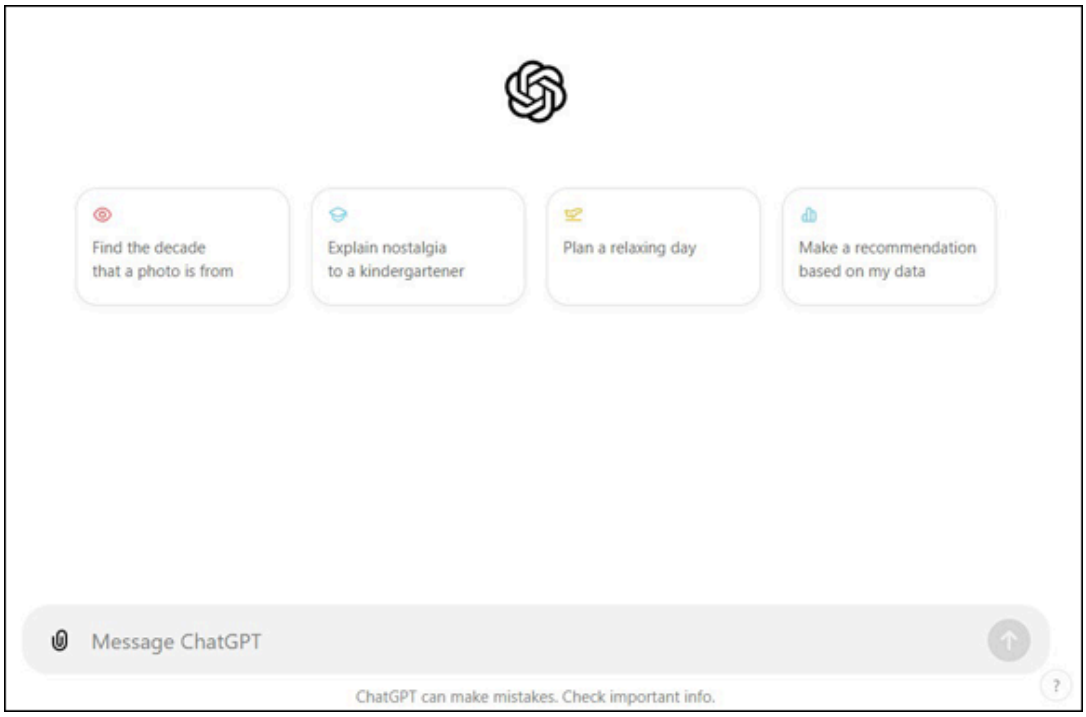


FIGURE 4-7: Screenshot of the mid- to lower center of the UI showing the OpenAI logo, sample prompts, the prompt bar, disclaimer, and help key.

10. Across the bottom of the prompt bar are three icons on the left and one on the far right (see Figure 4-8). The three on the left are a paper clip to attach files to the prompt, a toolbox to reveal tools you may want to use in the prompt like "search the web" and other GPT applications, and a standalone globe for direct access to an internet search. The single icon on the bottom far right of the prompt bar activates voice mode.
11. The question mark at the lower right of the UI reveals a menu of FAQs, help, release notes, terms and policies, and keyboard shortcuts.



FIGURE 4-8: A closeup of the prompt bar showing four icons: a paper clip, toolbox, globe, and a sound icon.



WARNING ChatGPT generates rather than regurgitates content, which means it can make erroneous assumptions and responses that are commonly referred to as hallucinations. ChatGPT or any other generative AI model isn't an infallible source of truth, a trustworthy narrator, or an authority on any topic, even when you prompt it to behave like one. In some circumstances, accepting it as an oracle or a single source of truth is a grave error.

Selecting a GPT Model on the ChatGPT UI

Generative pre-trained transformers (GPTs) are an advanced type of artificial intelligence model with a core function of generating human-like text by predicting subsequent words from your prompt, thereby completing a pattern generated in that input sequence. But some advanced GPT models have expanded capabilities, including the ability to process and generate images. You interact with a GPT model through an application like ChatGPT, which is a GPT-based chatbot, or Dall-E, which is also accessible through the ChatGPT toolbox at the bottom of the prompt bar.

Model options in the drop-down menu

The drop-down menu on ChatGPT's UI offers several GPT model options, each with distinct capabilities, as listed in the following mini table.

The model options	***Characteristics***
GPT-4	An advanced model, capable of managing many complex tasks, such as in-depth analysis, writing tasks, code writing, and problem-solving.
GPT-4 Turbo	An optimized version of GPT-4, meaning it is designed to be faster, more efficient, and capable of handling longer contexts better than previous versions.
GPT-40 (aka Omni)	A newer model that's multimodal (meaning it can process more formats than just text) that's faster than GPT-4 Turbo.
GPT-40 mini	A lighter variant of GPT-4o because it's built on a small language model (SLM) rather than a large language model (LLM). In other words, GPT 40 mini is a downsized version of GPT 40.

LLMs are large, general-purpose models. SLMs are typically but not always focused on specialized tasks with smaller computational requirements. SLMs are fast, efficient, and generally cheaper. Additionally, they're typically small enough to reside on a device rather than only in a datacenter.



TIP Overall, you should select a model based on your project requirements. If you're just exploring ChatGPT capabilities, you'll usually find whatever GPT model is the default listing on the UI to be sufficient. Typically, users find GPT-4o to be the ideal choice for most tasks.

The GPT's latest release

The latest release is GPT-o1 (formerly Strawberry) and is the start of a new model series. It aims to improve performance primarily through "spending more time thinking," says OpenAI. But because GPTs don't "think," this really means that this new model series does deeper data analysis, uses increased contextualization, and focuses on improved analytical capabilities, primarily focused on areas like mathematics, coding, and scientific problem-solving.

The GPT-o1 model often responds slower to more complex prompts because it's delving deeper into data analysis in search of an appropriate response. However, many users experience no difference between GPT-4o and GPT-o1 in response speeds because the prompts they use aren't complex enough to require a heftier model workout.

The GPT-o1-mini and GPT-4o-mini models are optimized for speed and efficiency, focusing on lighter tasks that require quick responses. They may not be as robust in handling complex queries as their bigger brethren of a similar name, but each excels in providing answers more efficiently.

Considering GPT Minis in the GPT Store on the ChatGPT UI

This part can get a bit confusing. As explained in the previous section, GPTs are a type of AI model that ChatGPT runs on. But here, the term GPTs is used to denote a version of ChatGPT that's tailored for a specific purpose that you can use within ChatGPT. I know, right??! You would think OpenAI would choose a different moniker for these to cut down on the confusion, but alas, no.

Each of these GPTs is optimized for particular work processes such as writing, coding, and providing expert advice in areas such as marketing and data analysis.

Feel free to look around the GPT Store to see what's available by clicking on the Explore GPTs button on the sidebar on the left side of the ChatGPT UI or by going to `https://chatgpt.com/gpts`. You can elect to use one of these for your project or return to the original ChatGPT UI and work with that.

Should you want to experiment or use one, following is some simple guidance on selecting GPTs from ChatGPT's GPT Store:

1. **Start by clicking on the Explore GPTs button.**
   You'll find the button near the top of the sidebar on the left side of the ChatGPT UI. That will take you to the GPT Store. You can use search or the topic buttons to quickly move to the type of GPTs you seek, or you can simply scroll to discover all the different options.
2. **Check the descriptions.**
   Each GPT has a short description of what it's designed to do. Before selecting a GPT, read through these descriptions to see if that particular GPT fits the task you have in mind. For example, if you need help drafting an email, you might pick a GPT focused on writing. If you're doing data analysis or writing computer code, choose one tailored for that purpose.
3. **Consider user reviews.**
   Some of the GPTs have reviews or ratings that indicate what other users think. Higher ratings usually indicate more reliable performance for that specific type of task. Click on a GPT to see its rating and how many other people use it.
4. **Start with general GPTs and then get specific.**
   If you're unsure where to start, try a general-purpose GPT first. You may want to return to the ChatGPT UI and use that to see if this general-purpose chatbot is sufficient for your needs. General-purpose GPTs and the main ChatGPT chatbot are great for everyday questions and tasks. After you become familiar with

them, you can explore more specialized GPTs for complex or niche tasks. In other words, you don't have to select any of the GPTs from the GPT Store. Those are simply there in case you want to use a more specialized application.



TIP You can copy the output from one or more GPTs and combine it with the response from ChatGPT for a better overall result. Or you can use one or more responses from GPTs as part or all of a prompt in ChatGPT, or vice versa. In the end, your content will likely be much more informed, creative, and polished if you use your own creativity and critical thinking to build upon outputs/responses rather than accept any one response "as is."

5. **Switch GPTs if needed.**
   You aren't stuck with the first GPT you choose. If the one you selected isn't quite working for what you need, feel free to switch to another one at any time. And don't feel like you must always use certain GPTs in future chats. Check the GPT Store often for new GPTs or upgrades to your favorites.
6. **Experiment with new GPTs.**
   Some GPTs may be designed for emerging or niche needs. Don't hesitate to try out new ones for special projects or if you're curious about their capabilities. Besides, doing so may spark a new creative idea for you. Kick the tires, take GPTs out for a drive, keep what you need, and abandon what you don't.
7. **Remember that ChatGPT will collect the GPTs for you.**
   Once you select a GPT, ChatGPT will list it in the sidebar of its UI. That way you don't have to remember the GPT's name or where to find it. A simple click takes you right to it. If you don't want a GPT to show in the sidebar, roll over the GPT in the sidebar list to reveal three dots. Roll over or click the dots to reveal the options "keep in sidebar" and "hide from sidebar." Click on your selection.

Rendering ChatGPT Outputs to Final Forms

ChatGPT specializes in generating and processing text based on your prompts. If you select a multimodal model, ChatGPT can work with more than text. Although the responses can be amazing, they aren't typically useful in this form. This means you'll likely need to take additional steps outside of ChatGPT. Here are some examples of why outputs typically need to be copied and pasted or otherwise transferred to other software for production tasks like layout and publication:

- **Specialized tools:** Layout and publication often require specialized software, such as Adobe InDesign, for print layout or WordPress for web content manage-

ment. These tools offer advanced features for design and formatting that aren't part of ChatGPT's text generation capabilities.

- **Complex formatting:** Professional layouts involve intricate design elements like columns, margins, fonts, and graphics. ChatGPT can't manipulate visual elements or handle such detailed formatting.
- **Interactivity and media:** Modern content often includes interactive features or multimedia, such as hyperlinks, videos, and animations. Embedding and properly configuring these elements typically requires software that's specifically designed for interactive content creation.
- **Platform-specific requirements:** Different platforms have unique requirements for content publication. For instance, an ebook requires a different format than a blog post. ChatGPT isn't built to understand or adhere to these platform-specific nuances.
- **User experience:** Ensuring a good user experience involves testing how content looks and functions on various devices and browsers. ChatGPT doesn't have the capability to test or optimize content across different environments.
- **Compliance and accessibility:** Content often needs to meet certain compliance standards, such as the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) for accessibility or General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) for privacy. Specialized software can ensure that the final product complies with these regulations.
- **Collaboration and workflow:** Production processes often involve multiple stakeholders, including designers, editors, and legal teams. Software designed for production typically includes features for collaboration and workflow management that ChatGPT doesn't have.
- **Quality control:** Before publication, ChatGPT-generated content must go through a quality control process. This might include proofreading, fact-checking, and design review, which are tasks that require human judgment and tools beyond ChatGPT's text-based capabilities.
- **Final output and distribution:** Finally, the content needs to be exported in a format suitable for distribution, such as PDF for print or HTML for the web. ChatGPT doesn't handle file conversions or distribution logistics.

ChatGPT can generate helpful content elements, but taking it to production level involves a range of tasks that are visual, interactive, and specific to the platform. These tasks require the use of specialized software to ensure the content is well designed, compliant, and optimized for the end user's experience. ChatGPT simply can't perform these tasks.

PROS AND CONS OF CHATGPT

ChatGPT is widely used by millions of individuals and organizations worldwide. However, like all technologies, ChatGPT has both pros and cons to consider. By being aware of these, you can leverage the good, plan how to offset the bad, and increase the odds that all will go well with your projects!

Pros	Cons
Fast responses	Sometimes inaccurate
Delivers unified answer	Varying quality
Conversational	Sometimes repetitive or offensive
Wide range of capabilities	Convincing even when wrong
Many applications	Conversations aren’t private
Generates content	Not permitted by many companies who fear liability issues from wrong content